

Trench Warfare V2 - Game Design Document (GDD)

Title: Trench Warfare

Genre: Tactical Autobattler

Setting: Low Sci-Fi, Near-Future, Alternate History

Tone: Grimdark with Tongue-in-Cheek Elements

Inspirations: Warhammer 40K, Fallout, Darkest Dungeon, This War of Mine, The Bazaar, Top Troops!, Tower Domination, Once Upon a Galaxy

Version: V2 (POC-Focused Refinement)

Overview: This GDD refines the original design for a proof-of-concept (POC) demo, emphasizing a tight core loop with fixed 90-second battles, mid-battle tactics, and ghost opponents. Full-scope elements (e.g., async multiplayer ghosts, variable timers, expanded factions) are parked in an appendix for future expansion. The demo targets quick playtesting (5-10 min runs) to validate combat feel, faction asymmetry, and tactical depth.

Core Concept

A single-player tactical autobattler in a world of endless trench warfare. Players build armies of tanks and infantry, customize HQ modules, and intervene mid-battle to sway automated fights. High-stakes roguelite elements include permanent unit death and persistent HQ damage. For the POC demo, focus on survival runs against pre-seeded opponents, with wins building toward a 10-battle streak.

Player Objectives:

- Deploy units and modules pre-battle.
- Survive 90-second automated battles with tactical interventions.
- Protect the HQ across a run of up to 10 battles.

Key Features (POC Demo):

- **Fixed Battle Duration:** 90 seconds per battle, with early endings on full wipeouts.
- **Mid-Battle Tactics:** Interventions at 30s and 60s (2 per battle).

- **Permanent Death:** Lost units are gone; HQ damage persists until destruction (run end).
 - **Ghost Opponents:** Semi-random pre-seeded enemy setups (3 templates per round: aggressive, defensive, balanced).
 - **Factions:** Limited to 2 for contrast and testing (Ironmarch Union vs. Dust Scourge).
 - **Run Structure:** Play until HQ destroyed or 10 wins. Demo caps at 5 battles for quick testing, with a "demo victory" on 5 wins.
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Gameplay Overview

Run Structure

- **Length:** Up to 10 battles (win streak) or HQ destruction. *Demo: Cap at 5 battles for brevity.*
- **Progression Between Battles:** Earn resources from performance (e.g., bonuses for no HQ damage, high kills) to shop for 1-3 unit/module upgrades. Revive 1 unit per win. *Minimal shop: 2-3 options per intermission.*
- **Win/Loss Conditions:**
 - Battle Win: Enemy wipeout before 90s, or at 90s: most enemy units killed + HQ damage dealt.
 - Battle Loss: Player wipeout or heavy HQ damage.
 - Run Win: 10 battle streak (score based on total kills/efficiency; streaks/badges for replay).
 - Run Loss: HQ destroyed.
- **Early Wipeout Handling:** Battle ends immediately. If player front line dies, rear units defend HQ but take bonus enemy damage. Enemy wipe = auto-win with full rewards.

Battle Flow

- **Setup Phase:** Deploy units on grid, assign ammo, choose modules.

- **Combat Phase:** Automated fighting starts. Timer counts to 90s.
 - Tactics at 30s and 60s: Player chooses from defaults.
 - Escalation: Waves or enemy pushes every 30s for tension.
- **Resolution:**
 - At 90s (if no wipe): Winner by kill count + damage metrics. Tie = draw (minimal rewards).
 - Visuals: Countdown UI, escalating music/sounds (e.g., artillery buildup).

Mid-Battle Tactical System

- **Timing:** Interventions at 30s and 60s (2 total per battle).
- **Default Options (POC Simple Set):**
 - **Charge:** +15% damage, -10% armor.
 - **Retreat:** +15% armor, -20% movement speed.
 - **Carry On:** No changes.
- **Unlocks:** None in demo (parked for full scope via modules).

Battlefield Design

- **Grid Size:** 8x12 (shrunk for snappier 90s pacing).
 - Rows 1-2: No Man's Land (empty/hazards).
 - Rows 3-4: Trenches (frontline units; cover bonuses).
 - Rows 5-8: Rear Territory (modules, reserves, HQ in center bottom).
 - **Deployment Rules:** Units sized 1x1 to 2x2. Front rows fight actively; rear defends if breached.
 - **Visuals:** 2D top-down isometric. Pixel art trenches, explosions, grim industrial aesthetic. Tongue-in-cheek quips (e.g., Ironmarch unit: "For the Union—or scrap heap!").
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Resource System

- **Resources:** Fixed starting pool (100 per battle). Used for shop upgrades between battles.
 - **Ammo:** Starting 5 per battle. Regen 1 ammo every 30s. Governs special ability activations (no carryover).
 - **Income:** Performance bonuses (e.g., +20 resources for clean win). *Demo: No complex base income.*
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Factions (POC Demo: 2 Total)

Limited to Ironmarch Union (player default) vs. Dust Scourge (ghost enemies) for asymmetry testing: Heavy discipline vs. fast scavenging.

1. Ironmarch Union

- **Theme:** Soviet/Prussian militarism with industrial brutality.
- **Visuals:** Thick coats, riveted armor, tracked tanks.
- **Culture:** Hierarchical, sacrifice-driven.
- **Motto:** “Steel breaks, but the Union endures.”
- **Playstyle:** Tank-heavy defense, momentum via repairs.
- **Units (3):**
 - **Heavy Tank:** High HP, taunts enemies, slow. (Role: Tank; Attack: Ballistic.)
 - **Assault Infantry:** Burst damage, close-range. (Role: Damage.)
 - **Engineer:** Heals adjacent vehicles. (Role: Support.)
- **Modules (3):**
 - **Repair Bay:** Passive HQ/unit healing.
 - **Ammo Depot:** +1 ammo regen.
 - **Shield Gen:** Temporary armor buff.

2. Dust Scourge

- **Theme:** Nomadic raiders in desert-scarred wastelands.
- **Visuals:** Scrap vehicles, gas masks, flowing wraps.
- **Culture:** Brutal scavengers, hit-and-run.
- **Motto:** “We are the storm between empires.”
- **Playstyle:** Fast harassment, resource scavenging.
- **Units (3):**
 - **Scrap Buggy:** Fast light tank, high mobility. (Role: Utility; Attack: Piercing.)
 - **Raider Infantry:** Quick damage, evasion. (Role: Damage.)
 - **Scavenger:** Steals enemy resources mid-battle. (Role: Support.)
- **Modules (3):**
 - **Scavenge Boost:** Extra resources from kills.
 - **Smoke Screen:** Evasion boost.
 - **Flank Aid:** Bonus flanking damage.

Ghost Opponents: Dust Scourge setups. 3 pre-seeded templates per round (e.g., Round 1: Aggressive rush, Defensive turtle, Balanced mix). Randomly selected for variety.

Unit Design (General)

- **Core Stats:** HP, Attack Type (Ballistic/Piercing), Range, Speed, Role (Tank/Damage/Support).
- **Specials:** Ammo-gated (e.g., Heavy Tank taunt costs 1 ammo).
- **Permadeath:** Lost units gone; replacements via shop.

Support Modules (General)

- **Categories:** Offensive/Defensive/Utility (faction-flavored in demo).

- **Activation:** Passive or ammo-triggered.
 - **HQ Integration:** Modules attach to HQ; damage persists across battles.
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Tech & Polish (POC Demo)

- **Platform:** Unity prototype (PC/web; mobile-ready touch controls).
 - **Art/Sound:** Pixel art, basic explosions/particles. Industrial OST with somber horns, escalating tension. Tongue-in-cheek lore snippets/quips.
 - **Tutorial:** Battle #0 intro (guided deployment, first tactic).
 - **Testing Goals:** Core loop engagement, 90s tension, tactics impact, faction balance, ghost fairness.
 - **Playtime:** 5-10 mins per run (3-5 battles).
 - **Extras:** Basic score screen, restart button.
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Appendix: Full-Scope Elements (Parked for Post-POC)

- **Async Battles:** Fight "ghosts" of real players' setups from the same round (e.g., your Battle 3 vs. another's Battle 3 snapshot). Pool from completed runs; AI fallbacks. Like Once Upon a Galaxy/The Bazaar for ladder-style PvP without waits.
- **Battle Timer:** Variable (60-120s) based on map/faction/difficulty. Escalations (e.g., hazards at 60s+).
- **Factions:** Expand to 8-12 (e.g., keep Crimson Assembly, Blightborn Pact; flesh out Paradox Engine time-rewinds).
- **Progression:** Meta-unlocks (factions, modules), endless mode, daily challenges.
- **Mechanics Expansions:** Destructible terrain, weather, more tactics (Airstrike, Heal Wave), co-op.
- **Scope:** Single-player to async multiplayer; longer runs with branching encounters.